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Hiring Committee
Mahon Library, Lubbock Municipal Libraries
City of Lubbock
1314 Avenue K, Lubbock, TX 79401

Dear Hiring Committee,

I am applying for the Part-Time Library Aide position at the Mahon Library. Emptying returns, getting items sorted and back on the shelf in the right place, and keeping the shelves in order is what I already spend my working days doing. The difference is that my collection holds printed fundraising mail rather than library books.

My title is Direct Mail Production Manager at Young Americans for Liberty, and the collection I look after is the organization's archive of everything it has printed and mailed. Some of it went out to the entire donor file. Some of it was a single proposal prepared for one major donor. A sample of every piece comes back from the printer and I am the one who takes it in. I label what arrives and shelve it by campaign and mail code, I keep the shelves accurate as the collection grows across campaign years, and I pull a past piece whenever a writer or a director needs something to work from. It is a working collection that people retrieve from constantly rather than boxes in a closet.

When I inherited it, finding anything meant already knowing where it was. I designed a SQL database for the collection and defined a consistent record for every piece, so that a mail code or a campaign name would be enough to locate something. Then I worked back through several campaign years and cataloged the existing material against that standard. On top of the database I built a searchable reading room, which lets anyone in the department find a piece and see where the physical original sits on the shelf. That project is where I learned why consistent records matter, and it is why a job like this one reads to me as skilled work rather than simple work.

Your posting asks for someone who can carry out detailed routines at a high rate of accuracy. As a student registrar at Chapman University's Fowler School of Law I processed and approved more than five hundred exam records and transcripts, where a misfiled document had consequences for somebody's graduation. I staffed the service window there as well, as the first person students talked to, so helping somebody at a desk is familiar ground.

Before my current role I was Development Manager at the University of Austin, where part of my work was the campus library. The university was building that library largely from donated books, and I took the donations in and documented them. One of those gifts was a complete *Harvard Classics* set, which I handled from the first conversation with the donor through to the books being shelved. I gave them a tour of the library in person and kept them updated on where the set had ended up. I led visitor tours more generally as well. That is the work that turned a general interest in libraries into wanting to do this for a living.

Outside work I built two public websites. The Free Knowledge Library is a digital library of political literature drawn from across the ideological spectrum, where I designed the site, the database and the classification scheme, and built the catalog that readers search. The other is statetrack.net, which I developed to publish state campaign finance records for state house and state senate candidates in all fifty states.

I should be straightforward about why I am applying for a part-time aide position. I begin a Library and Information Services certificate at Central Community College in the spring, and I have already started the ALA's Library Support Staff Certification, with a master's in library and information science to follow. Working in a library while I study is worth a good deal more to me than the hours suggest, because it is the practical experience the coursework assumes you are getting somewhere, and I would rather build it behind a desk than only on paper. I should say plainly that I am able to relocate. I am in Austin now, and I am willing to move anywhere in Texas a position requires.

Thank you for your consideration. I would welcome the chance to talk about the role.

Sincerely,

Neal T. Gillespie